COLLEGE OF BUSINESS EDUCATION

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COURWhy should researchers use current and relevant sources? SE: BACHELOR OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

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Question 28. Why should researchers use current and relevant sources?

Qn . Why Researchers Must Use Current Sources

The quality of any research is only as strong as the sources it is built upon. Using current sources is not merely a stylistic preference it is a fundamental methodological requirement. Below are the core reasons, each explained in depth.

1. Accuracy and Reliability of Information

Knowledge in most fields is not static. Scientific discoveries, statistical data, legal frameworks, and social realities change continuously. A source that was accurate five or ten years ago may contain information that has since been disproven, revised, or superseded.

When a researcher relies on outdated sources, they risk presenting information that is factually incorrect or misleading to their audience. In disciplines such as medicine, public health, economics, and technology, outdated data can have serious real-world consequences.

Example: A researcher studying HIV treatment protocols who cites guidelines from 2010 may recommend outdated drug regimens that current medical practice has improved upon, potentially misleading healthcare practitioners.

2. Reflecting the Current State of Knowledge

Every field of study has an evolving body of knowledge. Researchers are expected to engage with what is currently known not what was known years or decades ago. Academic writing, particularly at postgraduate level, requires the researcher to demonstrate familiarity with the contemporary scholarly conversation.

Using current sources signals to readers and examiners that the researcher has conducted a thorough and up-to-date literature review. It shows intellectual rigour and academic seriousness.

USING CURRENT SOURCES	USING OUTEDATED SOURCES
Demonstrates awareness of recent developments	May miss breakthroughs that change the field
Shows academic rigour and thoroughness	Suggests incomplete or lazy research
Aligns findings with the latest evidence	May contradict current consensus
Builds credibility with examiners and peers	Undermines the validity of conclusions

3. Credibility and Academic Integrity

Credible research is built on credible sources. When a researcher uses current, peer-reviewed, authoritative sources, they strengthen the credibility of their entire work. Examiners, reviewers, and readers assess the quality of a researcher's sources as part of judging the quality of the research itself.

Conversely, using old, unreliable, or non-peer-reviewed sources especially when current alternatives exist signals poor scholarly standards and weakens the overall integrity of the work.

4. Avoiding Misinformation and Flawed Conclusions

Outdated or irrelevant sources may contain data, statistics, or conclusions that were based on flawed methodologies, biased samples, or limited technology available at the time. Subsequent research may have corrected these errors, but a researcher using the old source would unknowingly replicate the mistake.

5. Meeting Publication and Institutional Standards

Academic journals, universities, and research institutions typically require that sources cited be recent and peer-reviewed. Many universities specify that sources should ideally be published within the last 5 to 10 years, with exceptions for foundational or seminal works.

Failing to meet this standard can result in:

- Rejection of a paper or thesis by an academic journal or examiner
- Loss of marks in coursework or dissertation assessments
- Requests for major revisions before publication or approval

- Damage to the researcher's academic reputation

6. Supporting Valid and Well-Evidenced Arguments

The strength of an academic argument depends on the quality of the evidence supporting it. A well-constructed argument that is backed by current, peer-reviewed, relevant sources is persuasive and defensible. An argument supported only by outdated or weak sources is vulnerable to challenge and criticism.

Researchers should think of their sources as the foundation of a building. If the foundation is weak, cracked, or old, the entire structure is at risk of collapse regardless of how elegant the construction above it appears.

7. Ethical Responsibility

Research carries an ethical responsibility to the academic community, to practitioners who may act on the findings, and to society at large. Publishing or presenting research based on outdated, irrelevant, or non-credible sources is ethically problematic because it can mislead those who rely on the research to make decisions.

This is especially significant in fields such as:

- Medicine and public health — where treatment decisions affect lives
- Law and policy — where recommendations influence legislation
- Education — where findings shape teaching practices and curricula
- Environmental science — where data informs conservation and climate policy

Qn. Why Researchers Must Use Relevant Sources

A source can be recent yet still be entirely wrong for a particular research project. Relevance is the second critical dimension of source quality. A highly current but irrelevant source contributes nothing to the research and may actually distort the focus of the work.

1. Aligning Sources with the Research Question

Every source cited in a research paper must serve a specific purpose in relation to the central research question. Sources that are tangentially related, drawn from a different context, or addressing a different population may confuse the reader and weaken the argument.

2. Contextual and Geographic Relevance

Research findings are often contextually specific. A study conducted in the United States about urban housing policy may not be directly applicable to housing challenges in Nairobi or Lagos without careful contextualisation. Researchers must consider whether the context of a source matches the context of their own study.

3 Disciplinary Relevance

Different academic disciplines have distinct methodologies, vocabularies, and standards of evidence. A psychology article may use methods and draw conclusions that are not appropriate to cite as support in an economics paper, even if the topic appears similar on the surface.

Researchers should primarily draw sources from their own discipline, supplementing with interdisciplinary sources where genuinely justified and clearly acknowledged.

4. Relevance to the Argument Being Made

A common mistake among student researchers is including a source simply because it mentions a related keyword, without checking whether the source's actual argument or findings support the specific claim being made. This misuse of sources sometimes called 'padding' is considered poor academic practice.

Every citation should be purposeful. Each source should either:

- Provide evidence that directly supports a claim
- Present a counter-argument that the researcher then addresses
- Define or establish a concept central to the research
- Situate the research within the existing literature
- Provide data, statistics, or empirical findings used in analysis

5. Audience and Level of Relevance

The intended audience of a source matters. A source written for a general audience uses different language and depth than one written for specialists. For academic research, sources should be written for or by subject experts. Popular newspaper articles, unless the research is specifically about media coverage, are generally not appropriate as primary academic evidence.

Conclusion

Research is a systematic and disciplined pursuit of knowledge. Its value to the academic community, to professional practice, and to society depends entirely on the quality of the foundations upon which it is built. Current and relevant sources are those foundations.

A researcher who uses outdated information risks building arguments on a crumbling base. A researcher who uses irrelevant sources builds in the wrong direction entirely. Both errors compromise the validity, credibility, and utility of the research.